

## Chapter 41-2: Yearning

A snapping sound rang out, and the light returned—but it wasn't the divine sword's weak glow. Instead, it was a bright, brilliant hall. Night-illuminating pearls lit the interior like daylight, and the rocky floor gleamed with golden light.

A woman stood on the steps. At first, only her silhouette was visible—she was tall with straight shoulders that supported layers of magnificent robes. Her black hair was bound up with several golden hairpins, and jeweled tassels hung down from the crown of her head.

Seeming to hear movement, the woman slowly turned around. Her trailing robes slid in leaf-like curves at her feet. When her face was completely illuminated by the light, Ning Fuyi was struck by her stunning beauty.

That face's beauty couldn't be described as "toppling kingdoms" or "making fish sink and birds fall"<sup>1</sup>—it was like the sun and moon. Standing there, she naturally inspired reverence, making one dare not look too long.

Ning Fuyi's arm around Chu Qingqiu unconsciously tightened, earning her a light pat from the person in her arms, which made her loosen her grip.

"Tingfeng Divine Maiden?" Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke, her voice echoing in the spacious hall.

The woman looked at them both with surprise, her gaze inquisitive. She tilted her head slightly, studying them for a long time before walking down the steps step by step.

"Who are you?" she asked gently, then raised her head to gaze at the hall, her eyes filled with longing. "How long have I been dead? How do you know my name?"

"I am Chu Qingqiu," Chu Qingqiu said softly, holding the hairpin she had pulled from the corpse's body. "This hairpin is engraved with your name."

"This Divine Meteorite site has existed for over ten thousand years," she added.

So the figure before them was one of the corpses—the divine maiden and owner of the divine sword. But why, after ten thousand years, did she still retain a wisp of her soul in this small hairpin?

"Ten thousand years..." the divine maiden lowered her eyes, her gaze distant.

"Divine Maiden, do you know if this divine hall has any other exits?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"And who are you?" The divine maiden seemed to notice Ning Fuyi for the first time, her expression surprised. In the next instant, she suddenly appeared before Ning Fuyi, reaching out to touch her chin, but was instinctively blocked by Chu Qingqiu.

The divine maiden's hand stopped in mid-air. She looked at Ning Fuyi, then at Chu Qingqiu, her lips curving slightly. "Interesting."

The more Ning Fuyi looked at her, the stranger she seemed. Just as she was about to ask what was interesting, the divine maiden continued on her own: "Would you like to hear a story?"

"No," Ning Fuyi answered bluntly.

"I was born as the divine maiden of Zhaoyao Mountain<sup>3</sup>," the divine maiden said, her gaze drifting into the void. "From childhood, over a dozen aunts managed me, requiring me to guard Zhaoyao and protect the people of the world."

Ning Fuyi nearly rolled her eyes. Since she insisted on telling the story anyway, why bother asking?

"But in my youth, I didn't like hiding in these mountains. I often snuck out to play in the mortal realm, and that's how I met Mo Lan," she said with a smile. "Do you know who Mo Lan is?"

Chu Qingqiu shook her head, but Ning Fuyi said she had some knowledge.

Seeing both suddenly looking at her, Ning Fuyi opened her mouth and said: "The demon clan ancestor, Jun Mo Lan<sup>4</sup>."

"Yes." The divine maiden nodded, turning her back to them with her hands clasped behind her. "At that time, I didn't know she was a demon, and she didn't know I was a god. We often met in the mortal realm to play, and over time, we developed feelings for each other."

Ning Fuyi raised her eyebrows in surprise.

"Until later, when I donned armor to slay demons and monsters, and when we met in the mortal realm, I learned she was the demon everyone spoke of. We fought for three days and nights. She was ultimately no match for me, so I captured her and brought her back to the divine hall, imprisoning her in the dungeon."

"I didn't want to kill her, but the people begged me to slay her to bring peace to the world. I still couldn't bear to do it, so those begging people formed a long river at the foot of Zhaoyao Mountain, threatening death if I didn't comply."

"When people actually began taking their own lives, the once cloud-wreathed and rosy Zhaoyao Mountain instantly became a mountain of corpses and sea of blood. Only then did I finally bring her here."

"I still didn't want to kill her, but I knew I was the last god in the world, and gods should protect the common people and slay demons..."

"So you killed her?" Ning Fuyi asked coldly.

"No." The divine maiden looked at the divine sword in her hands. "She tricked me into fighting her, then when I wasn't paying attention, she seized the divine sword and stabbed it into her own chest."

Chu Qingqiu's shoulders trembled in Ning Fuyi's arms.

The divine maiden's long sigh echoed through the hall—sad, yet not sad.

"She fulfilled my path. I am worthy of the people."

The rest need not be said—the divine maiden must have pulled out her hairpin to end her own life.

Both Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi fell into silence. Ning Fuyi had never expected such a story. It was lamentable to hear, yet she couldn't say much about it.

"One mountain range, two mountain ranges. Mountains distant, sky high, smoke and water cold, yearning like maple leaves red<sup>5</sup>," the divine maiden recited, finally throwing the sword in her hands to Ning Fuyi.

"This sword is named Yearning<sup>6</sup>. Since you drew it out, it belongs to you."

The moment the sword landed in Ning Fuyi's hands, the divine hall from the memory began to collapse again. The divine maiden smiled at them as her originally lustrous skin visibly withered and fell away, finally becoming a white skeleton that quietly collapsed.

"Be careful!" Chu Qingqiu shouted, dragging Ning Fuyi backward. However, the ground around them had already completely caved in. The space beneath their feet suddenly became empty, and their bodies plummeted.

Countless stones clattered against their faces. Ning Fuyi couldn't open her eyes at all. In her confusion, someone held her tightly in their arms, then their body shook, and bright light flooded everything.

"Chu Ling Divine Venerable! It's Chu Ling Divine Venerable!"

"Ning Fuyi! Yiyi!"

"Quick, quick, quick, everyone move aside!"

Countless shouts made her head spin. Ning Fuyi struggled to get up, but the arms holding her seemed locked in place, not giving her any space at all.

Finally, she had no strength left to struggle. Her hand relaxed, and her face buried itself in a fragrant embrace as she fell into a deep sleep.

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### Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> **"Making fish sink and birds fall" (沉鱼落雁)** - A classical Chinese idiom describing extraordinary beauty that even nature is affected by it.

<sup>2</sup> **Tingfeng Divine Maiden (听枫神女)** - "Tingfeng" literally means "listening to maple trees," suggesting a connection to nature and autumn.

<sup>3</sup> **Zhaoyao Mountain (招摇山)** - A mystical mountain that serves as a sacred site, "Zhaoyao" can mean "ostentatious" or "flaunting."

<sup>4</sup> **Jun Mo Lan (君墨蘭)** - "Jun" is an honorific title, "Mo" relates to ink/black, and "Lan" can mean orchid or fence/barrier.

<sup>5</sup> **Classical poem** - This appears to be a traditional Chinese poem about separation and longing, using natural imagery.

<sup>6</sup> **Yearning (相思)** - The sword's name literally means "mutual longing" or "lovesickness," reflecting the tragic love story of its previous owners.